

EDM 101 – Ethics and Patients' Rights in Dental Medicine

Lecture 6

Confidentiality and Patients Records

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This classes learning outcomes

By the end of this lecture you are able to

- Explain the ethical importance of patient confidentiality in dental practice.
- Describe the types of information included in dental records and how they must be protected.
- Identify situations where confidentiality may ethically or legally be breached.



What Are Dental Records?

Dental records contain:

- A. Patient's personal information
- B. Medical history
- C. Diagnostic data
- D. Clinical notes
- E. Radiographs and photos
- F. Dentist–patient communication
- G. Consent documentation

These records help ensure continuity and quality of care.



Why Are Dental Records Important?

Dental records help:

1. Diagnose conditions
2. Plan treatment
3. Monitor patient progress
4. Communicate with other healthcare professionals
5. Protect dentist legally



Ethical Duty of Confidentiality

All dental professionals must:

- Protect patient information
- Use information only for healthcare purposes
- Prevent unauthorized access

Breaching confidentiality can lead to legal consequences.



Patient Rights

- A. Privacy
- B. Control over their personal information
- C. Access their health records
- D. Expect professional confidentiality



Health Records and Data Protection

Health records contain information about:

1. Physical health
2. Mental health
3. Medical conditions

These records must be protected by data protection laws.



Data Collectors

A data controller is the person responsible for managing patient information.

Responsibilities include:

1. Protecting patient data
2. Determining how data is used
3. Ensuring confidentiality



Access to Patient Information

Patient information should only be accessed by:

Access must be limited to those who need the information.

- A. Dentist
- B. Dental assistants
- C. Staff directly involved in treatment



Confidentiality After Death

- Confidentiality continues even after the patient dies.
- Ethical duty remains to protect patient information.



Securing Patient Information

The clinic environment must prevent others from overhearing patient discussions.

- Locked filing cabinets
- Password-protected computer systems
- Restricted access to electronic records
- Confidential conversations



Confidentiality in Clinic Design

Reception and treatment areas must be designed to:

1. Prevent conversations from being overheard
2. Protect patient privacy
3. Secure patient files



Social Media and Confidentiality

- Dentists must never post patient information online without permission.
- Even anonymized cases must be carefully protected.



Patient Photos

Before using patient photos:

- A. Obtain written consent
- B. Explain how images will be used
- C. Ensure patient identity protection



Ethical Basis of Confidentiality

- Autonomy
- Respect for persons
- Trust

Without confidentiality, patients may hide important information.



When Confidentiality May Be Breached

Confidentiality can be breached in exceptional situations:

These situations require careful ethical judgment.

1. Legal requirements
2. Protection of others from harm
3. Mandatory reporting (child abuse)



Dual Loyalty

Dual loyalty occurs when dentists have responsibilities toward:

- A. Patient
- B. Society
- C. Government
- D. Employers

Conflicts may arise between these responsibilities.



Example: Infectious Disease

Example ethical dilemma:

If a patient refuses to inform their partner about HIV risk, disclosure may sometimes be justified to protect others.



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Summary;

- A. Confidentiality is essential in healthcare
- B. Dental records must be secure
- C. Patient trust depends on privacy
- D. Breaches are allowed only in exceptional situations



Thank You!



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